

Anxiety Journaling Prompts Guide

32 structured prompts to externalize anxious thoughts, interrupt rumination, and build a consistent evening reflection habit — organized by use case.

Evidence-based approach: expressive writing (Pennebaker, 1997), CBT thought records, and structured worry-time protocols.

How To Use This Guide

Pick one prompt per session rather than working through the full list at once. Research on expressive writing (Pennebaker & Beall, 1986) found that writing about stressful topics for just 15-20 minutes, 3-4 times, produced measurable reductions in anxiety and physician visits over the following months. Consistency matters more than volume — a few honest sentences most days outperforms one long entry per month.

Section 1 — Morning Check-In

1. What is the first anxious thought that showed up today, and is it a fact or a prediction?
2. On a scale of 1-10, where is my baseline anxiety this morning, and what's different from yesterday?
3. What's one thing within my control today, and one thing I need to consciously let go of?
4. What did I sleep, eat, or drink yesterday that might be amplifying anxiety today?
5. If today goes reasonably well, what will that actually look like?
6. What's the smallest next action I can take in the next 10 minutes?
7. Which of today's worries are about something happening now vs. something that might happen later?
8. What would I tell a friend who described today's worry to me?

Section 2 — Structured Worry Time

Based on stimulus control / worry postponement protocols used in CBT for generalized anxiety.

1. What am I worried about right now, written in one plain sentence?
2. Is this worry solvable today, or is it about something outside my current control?
3. If solvable: what is one concrete step I can take before this time tomorrow?
4. If not solvable: what would it look like to set this down until tomorrow's worry time?
5. What is the actual evidence for this worry, separate from the feeling of it?
6. What is the worst realistic outcome, and could I survive and adapt to it?
7. What is the most likely outcome, based on how similar situations have gone before?
8. Am I trying to control an outcome, or am I trying to control the uncertainty itself?

Section 3 — Naming Cognitive Distortions

1. Catastrophizing: Am I assuming the worst-case outcome is the likely outcome?
2. Mind reading: Am I assuming I know what someone else is thinking without evidence?
3. All-or-nothing: Am I treating a partial setback as total failure?
4. Fortune telling: Am I predicting a bad outcome as if it's already certain?

Section 4 — Evening Reflection

1. What went differently than my anxious prediction from this morning?
2. What's one moment today where I handled discomfort better than I expected?
3. What anxious thought turned out to be disproportionate to what actually happened?
4. What's one thing I'm carrying into tomorrow that I could set down tonight instead?
5. Did I use any avoidance today that gave short-term relief but reinforced the anxiety long-term?
6. What is one fact about today I'm certain of, separate from how I felt about it?
7. What's one thing, however small, that went well today?
8. What do I need — rest, connection, movement, or quiet — before tomorrow?

Section 5 — When Anxiety Spikes Suddenly

1. What just happened right before this spike — a thought, a message, a memory?
2. Where do I feel this in my body right now, specifically?
3. Is this a threat I need to act on, or a sensation I need to let pass?
4. What is one thing I can see, hear, and physically feel right now?